FireWire / IEEE 1394 / i.LINK / Lynx

FireWire is an uncommon interface to come across. The IEEE 1394 standard as it is officially known is called by different names by different manufacturers. Apple calls it FireWire, Sony's version is called i.LINK and TI calls it Lynx. Chances are you'll never come across these are there are much widely accepted interfaces like the USB and eSATA that completely outshine the IEEE 1294 in terms of market share and compatibility. They are however, found on video cameras. The two common variants namely FireWire 400 and FireWire 800 boast of transfer speeds of 400 Mbit/s and 800 Mbit/s respectively.

Thunderbolt

The Thunderbolt is only two years old and is yet to be widely adopted. Apple's devices will feature these ports as a standard so more Apple portable storage devices come with the Thunderbolt port as a standard rather than USB. Also, these portable devices can only be used on Apple and Linux devices out of the box as the file system is different as compared to Windows. They deliver high transfer speeds averaging 10 Gbit/s and the next revision is supposed to deliver twice the current rate of transfer.

eSATA / eSATAp

eSATA stands for external SATA and as the name suggests is an extension of the SATA port for data transfer devices. These ports don't supply power to the device so external power is needed in all cases. Sometimes the eSATA port has a power molex socket next to it for the same reason. These ports don't have any extra interface between them so they suffer the least from latency issues. The eSATAp is a variant of the eSATA which allows for power supply via the port. It is a combination of the USB and the eSATA ports and allows you to insert both devices alternatively, however, the power